Just beyond, another change in the making arises from the transition in American Administrations and the negotiations on Iran's nuclear programme and regional influence. Where that finds a landing point is of no small consequence. Paradoxically, West Asia has witnessed simultaneously a radical departure from past political battle lines as well as their intensification. The optimism of the Abraham Accords has been countered by the terrorist attacks on Israel. The resulting balance, however transitory, is still far from clear. What can be safely asserted is that this time around, the very underpinnings of West Asian politics are being transformed.

Quite autonomously, Western liberal politics is also increasingly at odds with regime comfort in some nations. It has triggered reappraisals that are enhanced by evolving global dynamics. On its part, the Abraham Accords are noteworthy not only for their departure from entrenched positions but for the promise that they hold, especially on economic and connectivity issues. The I2U2, a new grouping, contains the kernel of ideas that could suggest a greater Indian involvement. And that need not be the only game in town. Saudi Arabia's greater focus on Asia also offers openings for India. This includes the IMEC initiative with possibilities of cooperation in connectivity, logistics and energy. Building on a tradition of contacts between India and Europe that went through Arabia, it represents a 'return of history'. In the final analysis, the balance between entrenched politics and emerging economics will determine the region's relevance to the world beyond.

Insofar as Europe is concerned, even before the Ukraine shock, it had started emerging out of its fortress mentality. One sign of that was how gradually it had become more alive to its interests on a global scale. The adoption of policies by the European Union (EU) on the Indo-Pacific and on connectivity was a telling indication. However, the enormity of the Ukraine crisis obviously radically transformed the security outlook of individual states, as also of the collective. It fast-forwarded strategic globalism, as Europe itself chose to define the impact and responses in that framework. The challenge nevertheless remains that a continent, which fervently believed in 'change through trade' and was supremely clinical about its interests, now seeks the world's support and understanding. That it has cushioned itself from some of the sharper pains while advocating hard options for those much poorer makes this exercise much more difficult.